

# Evidence-based toddler behavior management guide with specific response scripts — Action Checklist

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## SHIFT YOUR MINDSET ABOUT AGGRESSION

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- ☐ **Recognize that aggression stems from reactive brain responses rather than intentional ones—a child cannot access impulse control before acting.:** Recognize that aggression stems from reactive brain responses rather than intentional ones—a child cannot access impulse control before acting.
- ☐ **Understand that the prefrontal cortex is only about 5% developed at this stage, not reaching full maturity until the mid-twenties.:** Understand that the prefrontal cortex is only about 5% developed at this stage, not reaching full maturity until the mid-twenties.
- ☐ **Accept that asking "Why did you do that?" doesn't work because their brain literally cannot provide a reason before the behavior.:** Accept that asking "Why did you do that?" doesn't work because their brain literally cannot provide a reason before the behavior.
- ☐ **Remember that your toddler isn't giving you a hard time—they're having a hard time, and the aggression is neurological, not personal.:** Remember that your toddler isn't giving you a hard time—they're having a hard time, and the aggression is neurological, not personal.

## REPLACE COMMANDS WITH POSITIVE SCRIPTS

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- ☐ **Replace "no hitting" with "Hands are gentle" or "We use gentle touches" so their brain holds the positive image instead.:** Replace "no hitting" with "Hands are gentle" or "We use gentle touches" so their brain holds the positive image instead.
- ☐ **Shift from "don't throw" to "Toys stay on the ground" to give your child a clear, positive behavior to follow.:** Shift from "don't throw" to "Toys stay on the ground" to give your child a clear, positive behavior to follow.
- ☐ **Use "Feet stay on the floor" instead of "don't run" because positive commands give your toddler a specific target to meet.:** Use "Feet stay on the floor" instead of "don't run" because positive commands give your toddler a specific target to meet.

- ☐ **Practice these positive scripts in the mirror tonight so the language feels natural when you need it in the moment.:** Practice these positive scripts in the mirror tonight so the language feels natural when you need it in the moment.

### TAKE PROTECTIVE ACTION AND GET SUPPORT

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- ☐ **Physically move away from aggressive behavior with a clear statement like "I have to protect my body" until your child can be safe.:** Physically move away from aggressive behavior with a clear statement like "I have to protect my body" until your child can be safe.
  - ☐ **Identify hunger, tiredness, overstimulation, or emotional overwhelm as underlying triggers and address them before frustration builds.:** Identify hunger, tiredness, overstimulation, or emotional overwhelm as underlying triggers and address them before frustration builds.
  - ☐ **Manage your own nervous system during conflicts because toddlers need a calm adult to help them regulate, not escalate.:** Manage your own nervous system during conflicts because toddlers need a calm adult to help them regulate, not escalate.
  - ☐ **Connect with PCIT or a child behavior specialist if aggression feels unmanageable—they can provide structured support for your family.:** Connect with PCIT or a child behavior specialist if aggression feels unmanageable—they can provide structured support for your family.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.